The Spot

By Stephen Dietz

CHUMLEY: *The Communications Director. Well-dressed. Nervous.*
WAGNER: *Director of "The Spot."*
NELSON: *The Pollster. Disheveled. Always working at a laptop computer. Often sipping from a diet soda.*
ROGER: *The Senior Advisor to the Candidate.*
BETSY: *A young mother.*
GLORIA: *A production assistant.*

INTRODUCTION

For more than a century, movie stars, famous athletes and musicians have all lent their star power to support presidential campaigns. Today the influence of celebrity endorsements continues to be a fascinating phenomenon in American politics.

Political endorsements can be a powerful device in swaying public opinion. But let's face it. It's gotten a little crazy lately!

In 2012, a cat named Mr. Nuts gained notoriety for predicting the presidential election based on which litter box he chose, although his prediction was based on his owners' preferences and ended up being incorrect.

And to stay with the cat-themed endorsements: In 2020, pop superstar Taylor Swift signed an Instagram post as "Taylor Swift -- Childless Cat Lady" while endorsing Democrat Kamala Harris for president. The remark was a reference to 3-year-old comment made by JD Vance, in which he described Democrats as beholden to "a bunch of childless cat ladies who are miserable at their own lives and the choices that they've made and so they want to make the rest of the country miserable, too."

Stephen Dietz takes a humorous look at political endorsements in The Spot.

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A chair and a small side table. On the table, a cup of tea. Surrounding this -- four people, all staring at the chair.

CHUMLEY: So, Roger, what we've envisioned -- and Wagner, just jump right on in here if I miss something -- what we envision for "The Spot" is a sort of solid, homespun, no-nonsense, eyes-right-into-the-camera kind of thing

WAGNER: Something that cries out: "Here-we-are-in-her-livingroom-and-she's-gonna-be-straight-with-us-so-help-her-God."

CHUMLEY: The young mother we've found -- and Wagner, correct me if I'm off-base here -

- this young mother is really just a *perfect choice* for

ROGER: She really a mother? She really have kids?

CHUMLEY: Well, as far as-

ROGER: People *want in,* Chumley. Everyone wants to be in "The Spot." They'll *lie through their teeth* to be in "The Spot."

WAGNER: She has kids.

ROGER: You've seen 'em? What are their names?

CHUMLEY: Roger, just to be clear, just to be what I like to call *crystal:* this woman's kids are *not* in "The Spot." It's just her. No kids in "The Spot." No kids at all.

ROGER: *(Immediately, to* WAGNER.) What are their names?

WAGNER: Joey and Gretchen.

ROGER: *(Immediately, to* NELSON.) I want those names *polled.*

NELSON: Right away, sir. *(Begins typing on her/his laptop.)*

CHUMLEY: Shall we bring her in and get started? Her name is

ROGER: I don't give a turd in a taco what her *name* is, WE'RE ON THE *CLOCK, GET HER BUTT IN HERE.*

WAGNER: *(Calls out.)* GLORIA- (GLORIA *appears-friendly and efficient.)*

GLORIA: *(To* WAGNER.) Yes, what can I do for you?

WAGNER: We're ready for the talent. (GLORIA *nods and is gone.)*

NELSON: Roger. **NELSON:** The name Joey polled at 78.

ROGER: Good. What about Gretchen?

NELSON: 31.

ROGER: Toss it out. How 'bout Sally? Run the numbers on Sally.

NELSON: Will do. *(Back to her/his laptop.)*

ROGER: Sally always *packs a punch.* (GLORIA *enters with* BETSY.)

GLORIA: Everyone: this is Betsy Taylor.

CHUMLEY: Betsy, I'd like you to meet Roger. He's the Senior Advisor to the Candidate.

BETSY: *(Extends her hand.)* A pleasure.

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ROGER: *(Suddenly.)* YOUR HAND? YOU WANT TO OFFER ME YOUR *HAND?* HOW *DARE* YOU TRY TO PULL A STUNT LIKE THIS? WHO DO YOU THINK YOU'RE *DEALING WITH? (It becomes clear that he is talking into his phone.)* THE DAY MY CANDIDATE SHAKES THE HAND OF SOMEONE FROM YOUR PARTY-YOUR *TRIBE* -- YOUR *GANG,* YOUR *CABAL*- IS THE DAY *PIGS WILL PLAY HOCKEY IN HELL!!! (He clicks the call off -. Turns pleasantly to* BETSY. *Extends his hand.)* Hi, there. I'm Roger. *(Before she can respond.)* I'm told you're a mother. Joey and Sally.

BETSY: Gretchen. My daughter-Gretchen.

ROGER: Sorry. It didn't poll.

NELSON: Sally's at 83.

ROGER: Sally polled like a champ. Rhymes with *rally-good* times ahead! You've got a daughter named Sally. You must be very happy. Mint? *(Offers her one.)*

CHUMLEY: *(Jumping in, nervous.)* Okay, let's get you in place, Betsy. (BETSY *sits in the chair.* WAGNER *approaches her.)*

WAGNER: Now, the *aesthetic* I'm working with in "The Spot" might well be called a "post-ironic, reality-infused, Mom-at-home" kind of thing-

CHUMLEY: Something I like to call *"honesty."* Are you with me?

WAGNER: And you're clear on the text?

CHUMLEY: What I call "the lines."

BETSY: Yes, I am.

WAGNER: Okay, then, people: let's shoot one.

GLORIA: *(Calling out.)* QUIET ON THE SET. ROLL SOUND.

WAGNER: And ... ACTION. (BETSY *looks straight ahead and speaks. Calm. Honest. Very good at this.)*

BETSY: Just the other day, my daughter ... *(Slight pause.) Sally* ... asked me who I was going to vote for. And I told her that there are three things I look for in a candidate: *trust, honor,* and *integrity. (She lifts her tea.)* And this year, only *one* candidate has all of-

ROGER: STOP RIGHT THERE! Set. The teacup. *Down. (She does.)* What are you *doing,* Betsy?

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Are you trying to *kill me?* Are you trying to *butcher my candidate?*

BETSY: *(confused.)* I'm not sure 1-

ROGER: Do you know the *numbers* on TEA? They are *abysmal.* Tell her the numbers on tea, Nelson.

NELSON: *(Helpfully.)* 17.

ROGER: Seventeen! The TEA is polling at SEVENTEEN and there you are in your little sweater and your little chair and you're LIFTING THE TEA TO YOUR LIPS. Why don't you just MAKE OUT WITH OJ and DANGLE A BABY OVER A BALCONY?

CHUMLEY: Roger, please, we're on a deadline-

ROGER: An *election,* Betsy -- this quaint little practice of people *going out to vote--that* is nothing but a *symbolic narcotic* to placate the populace. *(Grandly, to* NELSON.) THE *REAL* VOTES ARE NOT CAST *AT THE POLLS-BUT* WITH THE *POLLSTERS-with* great Americans like Nelson here. (NELSON *lifts her/his diet soda.)* And has the Carefully Polled Public voted for TEA, Betsy? *I think not.*

ROGER: Tell them, Nelson. Tell them who America wants Betsy to be.

NELSON: Well, in addition to Joey and Sally. You have a husband named Bill and a dog named Buster. *(Quickly consults new data on laptop.)* Correction! No husband- you're a *single mom.* You work at Wal-Mart. And your Joey's all grown up

BETSY: He's only nine!

NELSON: Sorry, ma'am: he's a soldier now, gone to rid the world of evil.

ROGER: Atta boy, Joey!

NELSON: And you're not sipping tea

ROGER: I told you!

NELSON: *(Overlapping.)* No, Betsy, you're sipping a Starbucks extra-hot low-fat double-tall mocha with *extra whipped cream*!

ROGER: *(Buoyantly.) THAT* IS THE WOMAN THEY WANT, Betsy-and, hey, don't look at me, I didn't invent her. She is the Love Child of Entitlement and Complacency. She is the PEOPLE'S CHOICE! NOW: LET'S SHOOT HER!

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GLORIA: *(Calling out)* QUIET ON THE SET. ROLL SOUND.

WAGNER: And ... ACTION.

BETSY: (*takes her place, about to begin. Then suddenly)* I won't do it. I just won't do it.

ROGER: You *won't do it?* What's *that* mean?

BETSY: It's not true-it's all a lie.

ROGER: Just what the hell kind of actress *are you,* anyway?

BETSY: I'm not an actress.

ROGER: Oh, you can say THAT again.

BETSY: *(Genuine, with passion.)* I'm a wife and a mother. I was chosen for "The Spot" because I really *believe in it.* I believe in your candidate. I want to give him my vote. When I look into the camera, I am speaking from my heart. *(Silence.* ROGER *turns to* CHUMLEY, *then* WAGNER, *then* NELSON, *as if to say: CAN THIS BE TRUE?* ROGER *turns back to* BETSY. *Approaches her slowly.)*

ROGER: Take off your sweater.

BETSY: But didn't you hear what I said? I really-

ROGER: Here's the thing about people who speak from their heart: I don't trust' em. Hearts are *fickle,* Betsy. *Hearts change.* And when the future of the free world is on the line, I can't be taking a chance on what *people believe in their hearts. (Beat. He stares at her hard.)* Take. It. Off. (BETSY, *staring right at* ROGER, *takes off her sweater. Underneath, attached with a strap over her shoulder, is a tape recorder.)* See there. Hand me the tape recorder. *(She does.) Is t*his another one of your TRICKS?!

BETSY: I'd like a chance to explain-

ROGER: *(Overlapping.)* ANOTHER WAY TO "SHAKE MY HAND"? SELL US OUT TO THE JACKALS AT JHE NETWORKS? IS THAT WHAT THIS IS?

BETSY: No, not at all- *(We realize that once again, he is speaking into his phone.)*

ROGER: What did they pay you? (BETSY *does not answer.)* Fess up, SuperMom. I know how they work. What did it cost them?

BETSY: I didn't want their money. I did it

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ROGER: Because of your *beliefs,* I suppose. What *you feel in your heart.*

BETSY: Yes.

ROGER: You disgust me. Get her out of here. (CHUMLEY *walks* BETSY *away, as-ROGER'S cell phone rings.) (Instantly, into phone.)* Yes? Mr. Candidate, great to hear from you, sir! It's going extremely well-couldn't be better! Yes, we'll send you a rough cut before the day is out. Thank you, sir. Good-bye. *(He ends the call.* CHUMLEY *rushes back in.)*

CHUMLEY: *(In a panic.)* Oh my god, Roger, we are just-I mean, Wagner, correct me if I'm wrong here-but it seems to me that we are now what I like to call *completely screwed.*

ROGER: *(Calmly.)* Nelson. **ROGER:** Run the numbers on "Gloria."

NELSON: Right away. *(Back to her/his laptop.)*

CHUMLEY: Roger, no- (ROGER *turns to* GLORIA.)

ROGER: Gloria, do you know the feeling we're going for?

GLORIA: Well, yes, but-

ROGER: And you're clear on the lines?

GLORIA: Yes, but I'm not really a-

ROGER: And do you *believe in them,* Gloria? Do you believe in them *deep in your heart? (Beat.)*

GLORIA: *(Simple, direct.)* Not at all.

ROGER: *THIS ONE's* got *MOXIE. THIS ONE* we can *SHOOT.*

CHUMLEY: Roger, *please*

ROGER: *(Exultant.)* PUT ON THE SWEATER! (WAGNER *leads* GLORIA *to the chair and helps her into the sweater and her microphone, powders her face, etc.) (Firing questions.)* Gloria, I want you to finish this sentence: my candidate is . . .

GLORIA: *(Firing back, enjoying herself) . . . dumb* as a box of hammers.

ROGER: You bet he is! And people like me are. . .

GLORIA: . . . the scum of the earth.

ROGER: You bet we are! Have a mint. *(She does.)*

NELSON: Gloria is polling at 93-

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ROGER: You bet she is! Gloria

WAGNER: QUIET ON THE SET.

ROGER: -rhymes with *euphoria!*

WAGNER: ROLL SOUND.

ROGER: And ... ACTION!

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Stephen Dietz
Book: Laugh Lines: Short Comedic Plays
ISBN: 978-0307277138
Publisher: Random House
Date (Month/Year): 2007

AWARD HISTORY

2008 National Qualifier
2014 National Qualifier

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